

A Homeowner Guide.

How to prepare your home for sale.

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Most homes don't need a full renovation.

They need the right preparation.

“What should I fix?”

That's the question every seller wants to answer. The mistake is answering it before you know who you're selling to.

The first question is: who's going to pay the most for my home, and what do they care about?

Skip this step and you lose money twice. You spend on work that doesn't help. And you miss the work that would have made buyers pay more.

One thing before we start. This is not another basic prep checklist. You've seen those, the same copy-paste list every agent hands out. A basic list ignores your home, your buyer, and your market. That is exactly how sellers waste money. If a checklist is what you're after, this guide isn't for you.

But if you want to build the right plan for your own home, without wasting a dollar, keep reading. By the end you'll know the mistakes to avoid, the 5 steps to follow, and how those steps sold one home for \$95,000 more than a neighbor's same model home.

Common mistakes I've seen sellers make.

Fix every item on the inspection report.

Buyers know homes aren't perfect. Fixing everything wastes your money.

Big landscaping project.

Cleanup, mulch, and trimmed edges around the lawn make the yard look 80% as good for 10% of the cost.

New tile or flooring in one area.

Buyers often replace all the flooring at once for one clean, modern look. New floors in one room get torn out with the rest.

Replace countertops.

You rarely get this money back. New countertops on old cabinets fool nobody. And buyers planning a kitchen redo replace them anyway.

Paint kitchen cabinets.

Paint doesn't make old cabinets better. The buyer replaces them anyway.

Lots of small fixes on a home that needs major work.

You'll spend a lot of money, and the buyer still sees a project.

The right or wrong call on every line above depends on knowing your home and your buyer.

I once represented a buyer in the Bay Area. The seller shared invoices for the prep work they did to get the house ready. Over \$50,000. My client was planning a full renovation right after purchase. Roughly \$47,000 of that prep work went straight in the dumpster. We gutted the cabinets the seller had repainted. Replaced the windows where they had painted the trim. Tore out the floors they refinished.

That seller prepped for the wrong buyer. The 5 steps below keep that from happening to you.

STEP 1 · KNOW YOUR BUYER

Who's buying in your area, and what are they paying?

Bay Area buyers aren't looking for the perfect home. They're looking for the best mix of compromises, like schools vs. price, space vs. commute, newer vs. older. Figure out the compromise that brings buyers to your area. That tells you who's choosing your home and what they care about.

Then learn what those buyers pay for each tier of home in your area. The 5 tiers, from lowest to highest:

1. **Teardown.** Priced near land value. Buyers are buying the lot, not the house.
2. **As-is project.** Needs a full renovation or a layout change. Buyers price both about the same.
3. **Cosmetic refresh.** The layout works, but everything shows its age. Old paint, old fixtures, dated colors. It feels like a project to many buyers even though it isn't one.
4. **Move-in ready.** Updated, clean, nothing major to do.
5. **Lifestyle home.** Some mix of: open floor plan, lots of light, big windows, easy access to the outdoors, newer finishes everywhere, nice design, higher ceilings, resort-style yard.

The price gaps between tiers decide everything. In some areas the gaps are small. Buyers stretching just to get in will pay nearly move-in ready prices for a tired home. Small gaps mean prep barely pays. Sell as-is. Wide gaps mean moving up one tier is worth serious money.

STEP 2 · LOOK AT YOUR HOME

Which tier is your home in today, and which tier could it reach?

Be realistic. Buyers will be.

If your home is tier 1 or 2, prep can't change its tier. No matter how many small fixes you make, buyers will still see a project.

From tier 3 up, moving up one tier is where the money is.

STEP 3 · LOOK AT YOUR NEIGHBORHOOD

Prices change neighborhood by neighborhood, not zip by zip.

A zip code is too big to set your price. School lines and major streets cut it into pockets, and the pockets sell for different prices. One side of a street can be a different school zone, a different price, and a different buyer than the other side.

These are the lines that divide neighborhoods inside a zip code:

- School district boundary
- Major streets
- View
- Walkability

Averaging home prices across a wider area misses these differences. You have to know which neighborhood you sit in to know what buyers will pay.

STEP 4 · LOOK AT YOUR COMPETITION

Who are you up against?

Look at homes for sale now and homes that recently sold, in three places:

1. Your neighborhood.
2. The neighborhood one step up. More desirable on the compromises that drive buyers (better schools, newer homes, more central).
3. The neighborhood one step down. Less desirable on the same compromises.

Buyers are comparing all three. Where your home fits in that comparison sets your price.

If the step-up neighborhood is offering similar homes at similar prices, you have a price limit. Buyers will go up to the better neighborhood instead. If the step-down neighborhood offers most of what your buyer wants for less, they may settle there.

Know where you fit before you spend a dollar. The competitive picture decides who you're prepping for and what it will take to win them.

STEP 5 · NOW DECIDE WHAT TO FIX

Show off what buyers can't change. Skip what they can fix later.

With the first 4 steps answered, the decision is simple. Spend only on work that does one of two things. It moves your home up a tier, or it keeps buyers from seeing it as a tier lower.

By tier:

- **Teardown.** Spend nothing.
- **As-is project.** Stay disciplined. Turn it into a clean blank slate and nothing more.
- **Tiers 3, 4, and 5.** This is where prep pays. Teardowns and projects sell in tight price ranges no matter what you do. In the higher tiers, the range of what buyers will pay is much wider. The right prep pushes you to the top of that range. Spend on what highlights the features that make your home stand out from the competition.

Selling as-is the right way.

There's still work to do, but the discipline is staying in this tier instead of half-climbing out of it. Spend only on turning the home into a clean, empty blank slate. Never spend on finishes a renovator will tear out.

Clear everything out. Scrub every window until it's crystal clear. Cut back the landscaping, clear the yard debris, and edge and trim so the grounds look neat.

If the home smells from pets or smoke, pull out the soft surfaces that hold the odor, like badly soiled carpet and old curtains. Bare subfloor looks rough, so lay down Ramboard, cut and taped neatly. At about 20 cents a square foot, it presents as a clean blank slate and won't hold smell the way carpet does.

There is one exception. If the roof or anything structural is failing, fix it and show the receipts and the warranty. A sound house with good bones is the best thing to sell in this tier. Buyers see the potential instead of the problems.

Now do the simple math. Step 1 told you what each tier sells for. Step 2 told you which tier you can reach. If moving up a tier adds \$100,000 and the prep costs \$20,000, it's an easy yes.

For every job on your list, ask one question. Would it change what the highest-paying buyer will pay? If not, skip it.

Keep this in mind: buyers judge a home by what they can't change. Everything else, they figure they can fix later.

HARD TO CHANGE

Layout. View. Grounds. High ceilings. Privacy. The design and architecture of the home.

EASIER TO CHANGE

Roof. Heating and cooling. Even a full kitchen or bath remodel.

When the hard things are right, buyers forgive the easy things. They know they can fix those later.

From the 5 steps to sold.

The 5 steps tell you what to fix. The list price, marketing, and negotiation turn that into the sale. Markets change. The framework doesn't.

THE BIG PICTURE: INTEREST RATES · ECONOMY · STOCK MARKET · HOMES FOR SALE

Weak market: dial back

Strong market: push harder



Here's how the framework looks for a real home in Silicon Valley.

Most prep means months of managing contractors on your own before the home ever hits the market. None of that happens here.

Running this framework for homeowners is what I do. I call it 16DayPrep, a full listing package. My team completes all of the prep in 16 days and has your home ready to hit the market on the 17th day. The prep is fully managed and the sale is executed together as one package.

What I handle:

- I walk your home and run the full analysis: your buyer, your tier, your neighborhood, your competition.
- I build the work list and the budget.
- I get bids from contractors and get them moving once you approve.
- I coordinate the prep day to day. You never need to be there.
- Then I run the sale: list price, marketing, negotiation.

What you handle:

- You approve every step from your phone.
- You pay contractors directly. No markup, no middleman.

Our last seller handed over the keys and didn't see the home again until it was staged, photographed, and ready to launch. He approved every step from his phone.

CASE STUDY

1458 Portobelo Dr.

San Jose, CA 95118

Same 5 steps. Specific decisions. Real numbers. Real results.

The 16-Day Prep.

BUYER POOL + HOME + NEIGHBORHOOD + COMPETITION + PREP

STEP 1 · BUYER POOL

Who's buying in your area, and what are they paying?

In these parts of San Jose, schools drive pricing and buyer decisions more than almost anything else. Many buyers pick the school boundary first, then look for the home. In the neighborhoods around this home, prices have historically followed the school ladder, with Leigh at the top, then Branham, then Pioneer.

The buyers who will pay the highest price for this home are school district buyers priced out of 95124 and 95125. These are buyers who would stretch their budget to get into the right school boundary.

Buyers who don't care about schools have better options. Elsewhere in 95118, the same money buys a bigger or nicer home. Those buyers won't pay the most for this one. They're not our target.

The buyers who will pay the most prefer Branham over Pioneer. It's the same compromise from Step 1. They want the school, at a price and in a home they can manage. We heard that preference directly from open house visitors.

That insight drove the entire prep strategy. We didn't need to be the best-presented home in 95118. We needed to win with one buyer, the family who wants Branham schools. For that family, this home had to be one of the better options at this price, presented better than anything else they could get in the good school boundaries, and clearly above the rest of 95118, where Pioneer is the school.

STEP 2 · THE HOME

Which tier is your home in today, and which tier could it reach?

As-is, the home didn't show well. The walls looked worn. The colors were dated. Doors were damaged. Recessed lights were broken. Gold and crystal chandeliers with ceiling medallions dated the home further. Heavy curtains and blinds blocked the natural light.

Underneath the surface, the home had a 28-year-old roof, a 35-year-old heating and cooling system, active termites, and an active plumbing leak in the master bath.

The bones were strong, though. The home had been updated in 2017 with basic kitchen and bath refreshes (now showing some age). The layout and flow were great. The floors were basic vinyl plank flooring that ran throughout the entire home, making it feel like one home. The windows were older sliding windows.

As-is, the home showed as a cosmetic refresh (tier 3). The opportunity was to push the presentation to move-in ready (tier 4). Moving up one tier would mean a significant jump in price.

STEP 3 · NEIGHBORHOOD

Prices change neighborhood by neighborhood, not zip by zip.

This specific pocket of 95118 feeds into Branham High School. The rest of 95118 feeds into Pioneer, and Pioneer homes price lower. That price gap shows buyers pay extra for Branham. Separating our pocket from the rest of 95118 was important for the final sale price.

The numbers alone don't catch this.

STEP 4 · COMPETITION

Who are you up against?

95118 prices below neighboring 95124 and 95125. Recent sales of similar homes put this home at \$1.78M–\$1.82M. We saw room to push higher.

A lot of homes in the surrounding neighborhoods are mainly functional. They may have the square footage, but the layout has compromises. Our home had a better layout and flow. We could compete on design too. Combined with the school advantage, that gave us room to push to the top of the range.

STEP 5 · PREP

Show off what buyers can't change. Skip what they can fix later.

The goal was to move the home up one tier in the buyer's eyes, from cosmetic refresh (tier 3) to move-in ready (tier 4). That one move is where the money was.

We did not fix the roof, the heating and cooling, the termites, or the plumbing leak. We also skipped any other repairs the home inspection flagged.

This pocket of 95118 has a price limit. \$40,000 in repairs does not raise it.

Spending that money would most likely have gotten us the same sale price. It would have handed the buyer a \$40,000 upgrade out of our seller's pocket. We kept that money in the seller's wallet and did only the prep that would raise the price.

We focused on bringing in light. We removed every curtain, blind, and window screen, then polished every window. We placed wall mirrors so a buyer walking in the front door saw a reflection of the backyard greenery. We painted the ceilings and trim the same color as the walls to minimize the low-ceiling effect.

It worked. In the buyer's eyes, the home showed as move-in ready. That tier jump is what drove the final sale price.

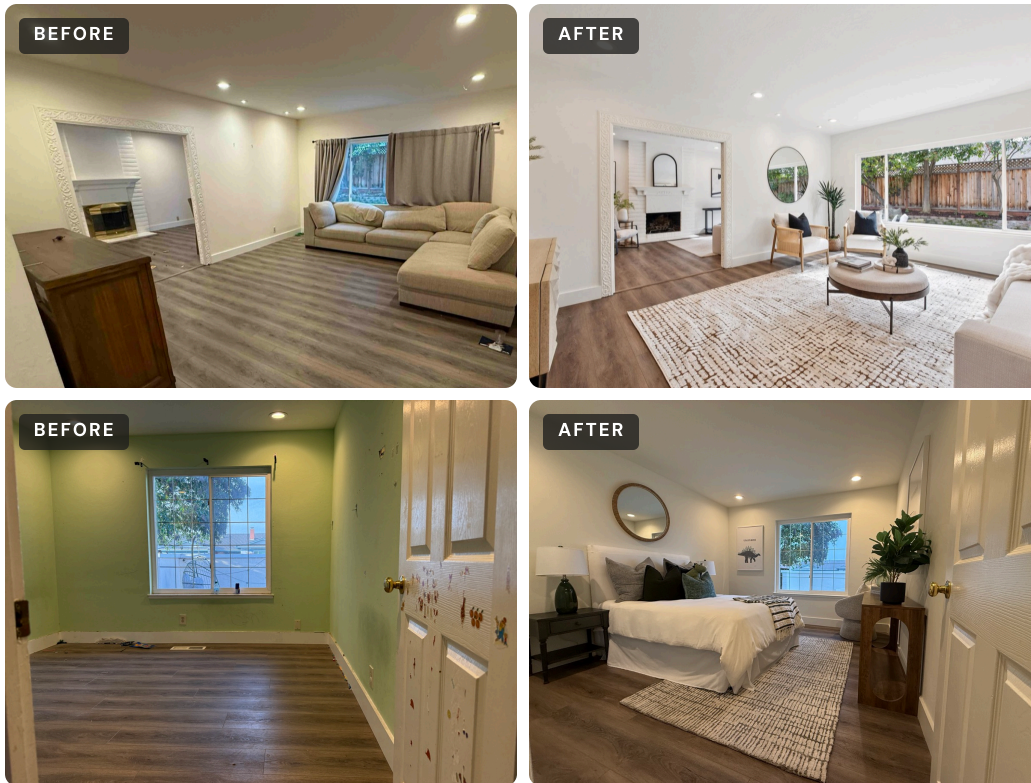
Prep cost breakdown

ITEM	PROJECTED	ACTUAL
Trash out	\$800	\$1,250
New interior flush mount lights / repair broken recessed / replace all light switches & outlets	\$1,500	\$1,350
Replacement glass shower door	\$1,000	\$975
Reglaze hall bath tub	\$750	\$635
Restore shower and bath tiles	\$500	\$950
Patching / repair / painting every surface interior & exterior / powerwash exterior	\$13,000	\$11,800
Yard mulch / cleanup / landscaping	\$350	\$1,200
Misc bulbs, light switch & outlet covers, attic cover	\$250	\$194
Smoke / CO detectors	\$150	\$100
Subtotal	\$18,350	\$18,454

Licensed trades: C-10 Electrician · C-33 Painter

Staging & presentation

Exterior paint: Edgecomb Gray with White Dove trim. Interior paint: White Dove on every surface, flat finish throughout. Large wall art installed. Top staging package at double the standard rate.



The Sale.

LIST PRICE + MARKETING + NEGOTIATION

The 5 steps gave us a range.

POSSIBLE LIST PRICE
\$1.70M – \$1.85M

LIST PRICE

How we priced it.

OPTION 1: \$1.488M

This price attracts buyers in the wrong price bracket. Many of them can't stretch to the price the home will actually sell for. A price this low mostly helps the agent brag they sold \$400K over asking. And if the bidding war doesn't happen, you're stuck raising the price. It's the right move only in rare situations, and this wasn't one of them.

OPTION 2: \$1.70M–\$1.79M

This price sends the wrong signal. The home gets grouped with the lower priced homes in 95118. \$1.79M is only \$10K below \$1.8M, but it reads like a different class of home. The sale likely tops out in the low \$1.8Ms.

OPTION 3: \$1.85M+

At this price, the home competes with 95124, 95125, and the Leigh school boundary. Against those neighborhoods, it loses.

OUR LIST PRICE

\$1.8M exactly.

This price separated the home from the lower priced homes in 95118, and it showed school district buyers from the pricier neighborhoods next door that this was the best value for their money.

MARKETING

How we find the right buyer.

Portobelo sold \$95,000 above the same model home nearby using only standard marketing, just MLS, professional photos, and open houses. The services below are how I've refined my approach since.

LOGICAL BUYER

Studies the numbers.
Compares prices.
Wants fair value or a deal.

EMOTIONAL BUYER

Falls in love.
Afraid of losing the home.
Willing to stretch to win.

The prep and presentation are designed to move buyers from the left column to the right.

Pre-Launch Agent Outreach.

I reach out directly to the buyer agents active in that exact zip code, before the home hits the MLS.

Targeted Out-of-Area Buyer Ads.

I run Facebook and Instagram ads in high-income cities to give out-of-area buyers early access.

DOMESTIC

Seattle, WA
Austin, TX
Boston, MA
New York City, NY
Los Angeles, CA

INTERNATIONAL

Bengaluru, India
Hyderabad, India
Beijing, China
Shanghai, China
Toronto, Canada
Vancouver, Canada
London, UK

Direct Buyer Offer Package.

A QR code at the door gives every visitor instant access to all inspections, disclosures, and the home video. It also captures their contact info, so serious buyers can make an offer on the spot.

NEGOTIATION

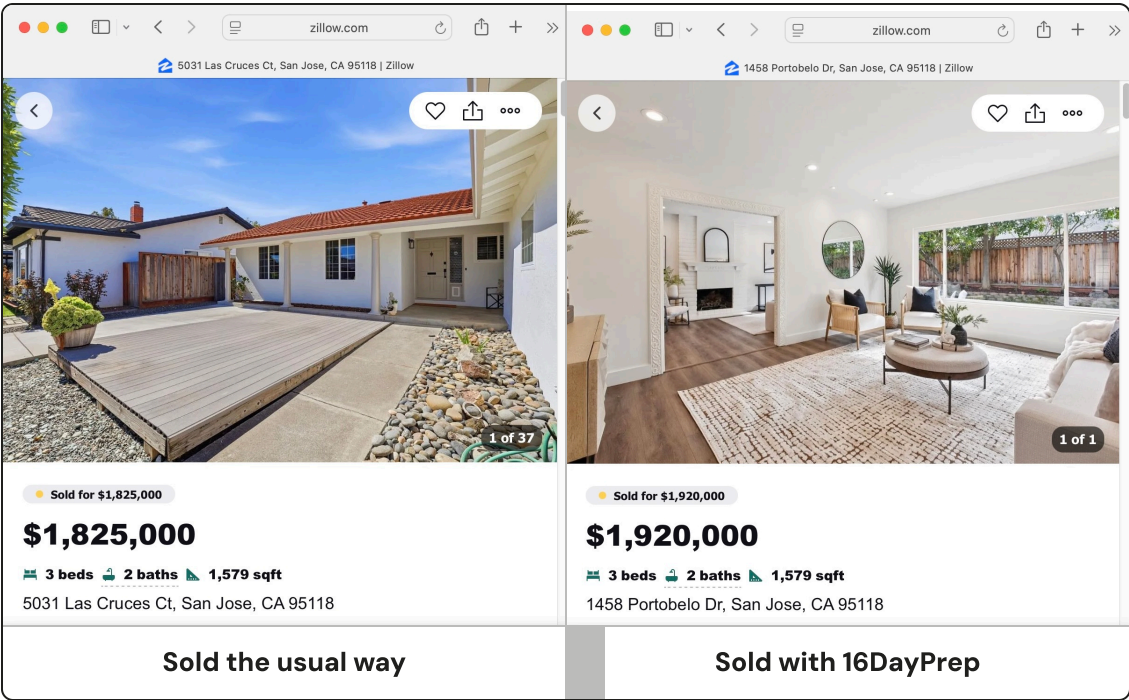
How we closed at \$1.92M.

We had multiple offers within 48 hours, and we ran multiple rounds of bidding. The specific negotiation details are kept confidential.

The Result.

\$95,000 more. 29 days faster.

Than the same model home around the corner. Same builder. Same year. Same square footage. Both fixed up and move-in ready. Listed 26 days apart.



“The other house must have been in worse condition.”

The opposite. Our home was in worse condition.

	5031 Las Cruces SOLD THE USUAL WAY	1458 Portobelo SOLD WITH 16DAYPREP
Fresh paint	Yes	Yes
Staging	Yes	Yes
Roof age	4 years	28 years
Heating/AC age	4 years	35 years
Termites	Clear	Active
Plumbing	Clear	Active leak
Sale price	\$1,825,000	\$1,920,000
Days on market	37 days	8 days

Actual results from a documented San Jose sale. Both homes: same builder, same model, same year built, same neighborhood, same lot size, same square footage, same layout, same schools, listed 26 days apart. Both marketed as move-in ready with updated kitchens and baths. Broker does not guarantee top-market premiums; results can vary by prep strategy and sales strategy.

Want the specific plan for your home? Call or text me at 408-759-1201 for a free walkthrough, or email hey@larrychou.com.